

Parkinson's Law

What is it?

Work expands to fill the time available.

If more time is given, the task will take longer — even if it doesn't need that much.

History

Introduced by Cyril Northcote Parkinson in **1955**, based on observations about time, bureaucracy, and productivity.

The Psychology Behind It

- People stretch work to match deadlines
- Extra time → extra overthinking + extra perfectionism
- Without time limits, tasks drag longer than required
- Clear boundaries = faster decisions and completion

Why It Matters

- Reduced efficiency
- Slow decision cycles
- Lower productivity
- Opportunity cost from wasted time

How to Apply It

- Set strict time constraints (limited time offers, demo timers)
- Reduce steps and simplify workflows
- Use progress indicators to encourage faster completion
- Pre-fill forms, use one-click actions
- Minimize UI complexity to prevent wandering

Theory in Action

- Booking.com uses countdown timers to speed user decisions
- McDonald's drive-thru enables fast purchase decisions with minimal steps

Final Thought

People slow down when there is too much time.

Fast, guided, time-bounded experiences help users finish tasks before hesitation takes over.

